All the gods attended their wedding but, according to local legend, refused to partake of the feast until Shiva had danced for them, for which he took on the form of Nataraja, the Lord of the Dance, to perform the cosmic dance now famous throughout India and abroad thanks to its vibrant portrayal in Chola bronze.

You could interpret Meenakshi's story as symbolising the process by which a powerful Dravidian female deity – a mother goddess or fertility goddess that may even have had her origins in a local warrior-queen – was absorbed into the fast-growing cult of Shiva in about the fourth or fifth century. However, what concerns us here is the tale told of three-breasted Meenakshi as a three-year-old. In that form she is said to have made three appearances: first to her parents out of a sacrificial fire, then to the seventeenth-century Tamil poet Kumaraguruparar when he presented his devotional poem *Meenakshi Amman Pillai Thamizh* to the public;[1] and finally to a British administrator named Rous Peter. That third appearance is said to have taken place about two decades after the EICo had taken over the administration of what the British termed the Carnatic from the Nawab of Arcot in 1801. It then became part of the official duties of the Collector and Magistrate of Madurai to act as the *thakkur* or civil guardian of the Meenakshi temple to ensure its smooth running.

One such *thakkur* was Rous Peter, a Cornishman from England whose father was the Member of Parliament for Bodmin – and whose unusual Christian name suggests that he was a red-head. He landed at Fort St George, Madras, in July 1801 aged sixteen, and after two years' training and language study was posted to Trichinopoly (Trichy), where he spent three years as an assistant to the District Collector. In 1807 he was moved to Madurai, where he remained for the rest of his life. In 1812 he was promoted Collector and